

The PX-712A and the Lite-On SOHW-1213S were the fastest at burning CDs—at speeds of 48X. CD burners may have reached 52X, but 48X is pretty fast. All the other contenders topped out at 40X. The Lite-On SOHW-1613S was the only one in this category to be able to burn DVD+Rs at 16X, making it the fastest to do so. AOpen's DRW4410R supported CD-R, CD-RW, DVD+R and DVD+RW, and it came with a decent software bundle—but no DVD-R support. The DVD+R and CD-R speeds of the AOpen maxed out at 4X and 12X respectively. All the others lapped the AOpen on this circuit.

The Plextor burners also offer notable features: VariRec, a recording mode that lets you adjust the power of the laser to produce CDs and DVDs that are compatible with non-PC hardware—such as music systems and desktop DVD players—and are also more reliable. GigaRec lets you burn 1 GB of data on a standard 700 MB CD-R, and SecuRec allows you to password protect data on your disks. These features add value to the drives.

### Performance

While taking server backups, you are talking several hundred gigabytes of data. Writing speeds are therefore very important when making a buying decision. Remember that read speeds matter too, since you will also need to restore the data you backed up.

The Plextor PX-712A aced the performance tests with the fastest DVD+R times at 12X as well as the fastest DVD-R burning times at 8X, coupled with great CD-R/RW scores. Media reading was also the fastest with the PX-712A. Surprisingly, the Plextor PX-708A failed the CD-RW tests with both UltraSpeed (24X) as well as UltraSpeed+ (32X) media. Also, the DVD-R

speed was limited to 4X despite its rated 8X, and DVD+RW scores were comparatively lower. The Sony DRU-540A posted some pretty impressive



**The Plextor PX-712A**

DVD±R/RW burning scores, followed by the Lite-On SOHW-1213S and the Asus DRW-1604P.

Amongst the losers was Samsung's TS-H542. While most burners could even overburn at 12X on 8X-rated DVD-R media, the TS-H542 only managed to write at 4X—even after a firmware upgrade.

Our assorted DVD+R test took almost twice the time that the sequential test took, which was quite strange since almost all the other writers gave very similar times for these two tests. The AOpen DRW4410R also had a 4X maximum speed for DVD+R burning, and as mentioned earlier, offered no support for DVD-R.

The Krypton DRW1008IM disappointed us with below-par DVD-R burning at 4X and DVD+R burning that started off at 8X, but, more often than not, dropped to 4X. We tried to upgrade the firmware hoping to improve the drive's media compatibility. However, we were unable to even get the update patch to recognise the Krypton as a compatible target drive!

### Price

This is totally Lite-On territory: With prices as low as Rs 4,495 and extremely competent performance, its SOHW-812S makes for the ultimate option, if your wallet is what you are thinking with. The next on the price podium is another Lite-On—the SOHW-1213S at Rs 4,750.

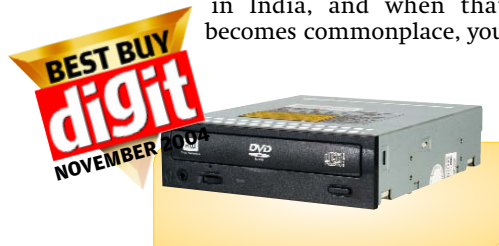
The Krypton drive may not have performed too well in the tests, but is affordable, at Rs 4,850. Plextor's 8X variant, the PX-708A, is competitively priced at Rs 5,500, but since it failed our CD-RW tests, we recommend you steer clear from it. The other Plextor, the PX-712A, at Rs 7,000, is the second-most expensive drive in this category, but has great per-

formance and features to back it up.

You might say you get what you pay for, but unfortunately, that's not true for all the drives: what the Sony DRU-540A gains in performance, it loses out in pricing. At Rs 7,500, it is the most expensive.

### Conclusion

Plextor's PX-712A is undoubtedly the best performer in the single-layer category. Though it has a comparatively high price tag of Rs 7,000, the extra features it provides, makes it a good deal. As of now, even 8X media is rare in India, and when that becomes commonplace, you



**The Lite-On SOHW-812S**

will be looking for 12X media.

Thus, buying the Plextor PX-712A (which has a 12X DVD+R speed) will future-proof your investment. But wait—the Plextor's score of 70.43 is not the highest. The Lite-On SOHW-812S runs past it by a whisker—70.47. How did that happen? Two factors: great price and decent performance.

Even so, the scores are too close to push one off to a lower level, so we decided to have a tie—both the Plextor PX-712A and the Lite-On SOHW-812S earn the Best Buy Gold award,



**The Lite-On SOHW-1213S**

and they deserve it.

The Best Buy Silver goes to the Lite-On SOHW-1213S for decent performance and affordable pricing.

### Dual-Layer DVD Writers

Most movie DVDs have 8 GB of video on what are called dual-layer DVDs or DVD9s.

They have been around for long, but consumers were deprived of this technology and

### FireWire

An external interface, first popularised by Apple. There are two types of FireWire ports, often referred to by their throughput—FireWire400 and FireWire800. Firewire400 is a relatively old standard and has a throughput of 400 Mbps, whereas the newer FireWire800 offers twice that speed.